Note: L to R: Students preparing for a competitive national defence examination. In the far corner is a Sangh altar adorned with its images of veneration. Photos by Rajiv Pundir and Nalin Mehta, Deendayal Dham, Mathura, 26 July 2020.

Our tour of the Deendayal Dham, conducted by a senior RSS leader, reminded me once again that ABVKA is only one among multiple Sangh initiatives focused on education. Even as Golwalkar mentored the creation of the Ashram in 1952, he laid the foundation of Gita Mandir in Kurukshetra. Parallel to this, the first Saraswati Shishu Mandir was set up in Gorakhpur in 1952. The Shishu Mandirs initially grew as a network of schools in UP. In 1958, a state-level committee was set up to supervise them.[67] As this education network expanded nationwide, in 1977, the Sangh set up the Vidya Bharati Akhil Bharatiya Shiksha Sansathan, a pan-India coordinating body, to supervise it. By 2020, Vidya Bharati's scholastic system included 12,363 educational institutions, including forty-nine colleges, 935 senior secondary schools, 2,232 middle schools, 4,369 primary schools, 2,951 pre-primary centres and 1,557 informal single-teacher schools.[68] The scholars Walter K. Andersen and Shridhar D. Damle have claimed that this constitutes 'by far the largest private school system in India'. In a sense, this education system had 'turned the tables on the concerns the Sangh once had regarding Christian missionary schools educating Hindus, as it now enrols a considerable number of Muslims and Christians'.[69] This is not surprising. The spick-and-span Saraswati Shishu Mandir we toured in Mathura had a large scholarship programme, a subsidised hostel and a significant student population from lower-income households.[70]

'In the decade after the [1948] ban, these schools provided an alternative way to spread the RSS's message of national unity and pan-Hinduism,' Andersen and Damle point out. 'Teachers at these schools often insert nationalist narratives into the social science and history books prescribed by national authorities, as these texts are held by some RSS circles to be devoid of respect for the country's distinct civilization. These schools also celebrate Hindu festivals and their facilities are typically adorned by Hindu religious symbols … these schools, like the shakhas, play a major role in